Don't Listen to What it Sounds Like

By Mark Borkowski

GRETCHEN: You sound like -

FLOYD: - what, I sound like what?

GRETCHEN: Like ... you're upset.

FLOYD: That's not true.

GRETCHEN: That's what it sounds like.

FLOYD: Don't listen to what it sounds like!

GRETCHEN: What d'ya mean don't listen to -

FLOYD: Because I didn't mean it that way.

INTRODUCTION

GRETCHEN: Recent studies have shown that only seven percent of the meaning of speech is what is literally said.
FLOYD: The other ninety-three percent is implied communication.
GRETCHEN: Body language,
FLOYD: Tone.
GRETCHEN: This is why children are chastised for having an attitude while answering "yes ma'am"
FLOYD: and why a wife can communicate great sorrow while claiming things are "fine."
GRETCHEN: Two former mental patients explore the detriments of tone in
BOTH: "Don't Listen to What it Sounds Like"
FLOYD: by Mark Borkowski

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(Floyd is already ranting at Gretchen. She sits in a chair politely listening ...)

FLOYD: My blood flowing from open wounds. My body hanging from a barbed wire

fence. My meat tearing from its thorns. Slipping onto the subway tracks and the subway car ravaging my body to pieces. Animals attacking me from all sides, ripping me apart. My tongue pulled out of my mouth. Decapitation. Castration. Fingers caught in table saws. My own personal apocalypse. Why am I haunted with these images?

GRETCHEN: It's ... good to see you again, Floyd.

FLOYD: You asked me what was on my mind.

GRETCHEN: I asked you. .. how you were doing. I'm sorry.

FLOYD: Why are you sorry? What have you got to be sorry for? For asking me?

GRETCHEN: No, not at all.

FLOYD: Well, that's that. It's off my chest ... for the moment. It's part of you now.

GRETCHEN: It's been a while.

FLOYD: Should be glad.

GRETCHEN: No.

FLOYD: Should count your lucky stars –

GRETCHEN: I missed you.

FLOYD: Missed me ? You know what it's been like - what I had to go through since I last saw you?

GRETCHEN: I'd like to know.

FLOYD: No you don't. I'm lucky I'm alive. Is that luck? Sometimes I wonder.

GRETCHEN: You look good.

FLOYD: Look, Gretch, you don't have to do that.

GRETCHEN: Do what?

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FLOYD: *You* look good.

RETCHEN: I moved back.

FLOYD: Why?

GRETCHEN: Variety of reasons. My mother's sick.

FLOYD: Sounds like the main reason.

GRETCHEN: It's up there.

FLOYD: She's a good woman. She was always good to me. She always brought me something. She came to see you every day.

GRETCHEN: SO did your mom.

FLOYD: Not every day. Christ, I been institutionalized so much the novelty wore off for her long before that.

GRETCHEN: She'd always bring cokes. You had a vanilla and I had--

FLOYD: Cherry coke. You hated vanilla.

GRETCHEN: Until I finally tried it.

FLOYD: Then you loved it.

GRETCHEN: I seem to be like that with everything.

FLOYD: Good woman, your mother.

GRETCHEN: In fact, I think I have some vanilla. I'm sure I have coke. I could make-

FLOYD: You really look good, Gretch.

GRETCHEN: I feel good.

FLOYD: Really. *(Pause, disappointed.)* That's good. *(Pause)*

GRETCHEN: Yeah, it's her heart. Mother always had problems with her heart.

FLOYD: She has a good heart, your mother.

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GRETCHEN: Physically, I mean.

FLOYD: She was always good to me.

GRETCHEN: Can I offer you anything?

FLOYD: Your mind...

GRETCHEN: What?

FLOYD: ... it feels ... OK?

GRETCHEN: My mind? It's a ... nice place these days.

FLOYD: How did you do it?

GRETCHEN: Do what?

FLOYD: Get yourself together.

GRETCHEN: Time.

FLOYD: Time? Don't make me laugh.

GRETCHEN: Why?

FLOYD: Time. *(Facetiously.)* I don't know, maybe we have different concepts of time. Maybe there's no space in my time. Too crowded to move so therefore it doesn't move at all - because that's what it feels like!

GRETCHEN: Floyd -

FLOYD: We were in the same place at the same time. One equally as fucked up as the other. We were on the same medications.

GRETCHEN: We had different illnesses.

FLOYD: We were diagnosed with the same thing. That's how we bonded or don't you remember? Our illnesses brought us together. Time. I've been in and out of institutions for the past fifteen years. Have you? *(Pause, no response from her.)* Well, have you?

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GRETCHEN: No.

FLOYD: No. Still taking your medication? Answer me, are you? Or did they up it - did they up your dosage?

GRETCHEN: No, they didn't.

FLOYD: And why didn't they?

GRETCHEN: Because I'm not taking medication anymore.

FLOYD: Right. So then, tell me, how-did-you-do-it? Your mind's "such a nice place these days," such a…resort area.

GRETCHEN: Look, I'm sorry if you're upset-

FLOYD: I'm just talking loudly - I'm not as upset as I sound.

GRETCHEN: You sound like -

FLOYD: - what, I sound like what?

GRETCHEN: Like ... you're upset, because...

FLOYD: Because why?

GRETCHEN: Because ... I'm better.

FLOYD: That's not true.

GRETCHEN: That's what it sounds like.

FLOYD: Don't listen to what it sounds like!

GRETCHEN: What d'ya mean don't listen to -

FLOYD: Because I didn't mean it that way. My God, you even have that look on your face.

GRETCHEN: What look?

FLOYD: That they do.

GRETCHEN: Who? Who the hell are you talking about?

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FLOYD: They'd have that look on their face - we use to imitate that look, we use to make fun of them. And now you got that look on your face, in your eyes, in the tone of your voice.

GRETCHEN: My voice?

FLOYD: That condescending voice.

GRETCHEN: I'm sorry, Floyd - I'm sorry you feel that –

FLOYD: What are you sorry for?

GRETCHEN: I'm allowed to be sorry! I'm allowed to be sorry for anything I wanna be sorry for!

FLOYD: I shouldn't be acting this way with you.

GRETCHEN: I understand.

FLOYD: You don't have to say that.

GRETCHEN: I'm not being condescending, I mean it - I understand. You think I don't remember how it feels?

FLOYD: Do you? Then why are you sorry? You have nothing to be sorry for. You look great, you sound great. Is that why you're sorry?

GRETCHEN: And I'm sorry I left.

FLOYD: Well...

GRETCHEN: And that I never wrote or called you ...

FLOYD: Wherever you went ... did you good. Maybe I should go there. Listen to me, as if there's actually a place you can fix things. Hotel Sanity. It's gotten really bad, Gretch. It's to the point where I can't go on a subway platform. I can't look at knives without my imagination using them. I see traffic-- I can't cross the street. Sometimes I run the

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other way. You know what it's like to not be able to cross the street? To stand there and watch old people, little kids, animals cross and there I am, paralyzed. Some days I can't even leave the house.

GRETCHEN: What does the doctor say?

FLOYD: He's sick of hearing it. You know how they get when you go on with something, over and over, for so long. They get bored, they look right through you.

GRETCHEN: I don't know what to say.

FLOYD: You always used to know what to say. You used to be so happy that somebody else felt the same way you did. We used to help each other.

GRETCHEN: God, I'm - I'm so removed from that state of mind then - then you'll say something and I'll ... I'll remember. Like what you just said. How I use to get excited when we'd talk? I felt so much comfort knowing I wasn't the only one.

FLOYD: I miss that.

GRETCHEN: I'm afraid of the things you say.

FLOYD: You didn't used to be.

GRETCHEN: I've put it behind me. I never wanna go back there again.

FLOYD: You were slicing your wrists every other week.

GRETCHEN: Horizontally, not vertically.

FLOYD: They were always repainting your room.

GRETCHEN: I always conveniently missed my pulse.

FLOYD: You attempted it - you telling me you didn't?

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GRETCHEN: It doesn't matter anymore.

FLOYD: For posterity sake.

GRETCHEN: Yes, I attempted it, but -

FLOYD: No buts! I don't wanna hear any buts! There are no buts! So ... you don't see things anymore? 'Member the little people? They used to get into your head and tell you to do things?

GRETCHEN: I don't hear them anymore.

FLOYD: You still see the hands, right? The hands that would come out from under your bed?

GRETCHEN: They stopped.

FLOYD: You still forget to breathe?

GRETCHEN: No.

FLOYD: Sometimes you do, right?

GRETCHEN: Not at all.

FLOYD: Do you at least still make yourself throw up after you eat?

GRETCHEN: I'm sorry.

FLOYD: I remember how we used to comfort each other. Do you forget that too?

GRETCHEN: Of course not.

FLOYD: We were sick together.

GRETCHEN: 'Member how we thought we were aliens?

FLOYD: And we just couldn't fit.

GRETCHEN: I fit now, Floyd.

FLOYD: Despite how I'm behaving I'm ... actually very happy for you. *(She hugs him.)*

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GRETCHEN: Let me make you that vanilla coke. We have a lot of catching up to do! *(Gretchen exits into the kitchen and fixes the drinks. Offstage)* I hope I have vanilla. Yes! You're in luck. You know I drink these all the time now. Can't believe I was so stubborn, never trying it, as much as you bugged and bugged me. Then I finally try it and I'm addicted to it. *(At some point Floyd quietly exits. She continues talking, oblivious that he is gone.)* I swear, I'm like that with everything. Avocados. Yogurt. I'm like "no-no-no," then I can't stop eating it. *(She enters, carrying the vanilla cokes.)* When I think of how many things I hate that I never tried - *(She suddenly stops, wondering where he is.)* Floyd? *(She walks across the room, looking for him.)* Floyd? *(She stops, realizing he is gone. She sits, still holding the vanilla cokes).*

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